

Two Kanikkar men demonstrate their fire-lighting skills.

Included among Caldwell's 'rude, black aborigines' were a tribe living in the mountains who called themselves Kanikkar, literally 'landowners'. In Caldwell's time these Kanikkar tribals could be found throughout the mountain forests of the most southerly section of the Western Ghats. According to the 1981 Census, today their descendants are reduced to fourteen thousand in number, most of them living in or near the four designated wildlife sanctuaries of the Agastya Malai hills between Thiruvananthapuram in Kerala and Kanyakumari and Tirunelveli in Tamil Nadu.

'The jungle Kanikars have no permanent abode, but shift about from one part of the forest to another. They live together in small communities under a *Muttakai* or headman, who presides over tribal council meetings, at which all social questions are discussed and settled. Their settlements, composed of lowly huts built of bamboo and